

LESSON 1

The Core Architecture: Nouns, Pronouns, and Verbless Clauses

SECTION 1: INTRODUCTION AND WARM-UP

Quick Summary

Welcome to Syriac, the dialect of Aramaic that became the literary language of Middle Eastern Christianity from the 2nd to the 8th centuries. Before diving into verbs or complex syntax, we must lay the foundation of the language: the alphabet, nouns, and how to string them together to make a sentence.

1. **The Alphabet:** The Syriac alphabet (Estrangela script) consists of 22 consonants, written right to left. Like Hebrew and Arabic, vowels were originally unwritten.
2. **The Noun System:** Syriac nouns have gender (masculine/feminine), number (singular/plural), and three “states” (absolute, construct, emphatic).
3. **The Emphatic State:** The default form of a Syriac noun. It ends in an Alaph (ܐ) and historically signaled the definite article (“the”), though in classical Syriac it is the standard dictionary form.

5-Question Baseline Drill

(Since this is Lesson 1, these questions reflect general Semitic language principles to prime your existing knowledge. Answers are in Section 9).

1. Semitic languages are built on root systems. How many consonants typically make up a root?
 2. Looking closely at the script, in which direction is Syriac written?
 3. What is a “verbless clause” in Hebrew or Arabic?
 4. What consonant do you think represents the ‘Alaph’ (the first letter)?
 5. If the Hebrew word for “king” is *melek* and Arabic is *malik*, what do you hypothesize the Aramaic/Syriac root consonants might be?
-

SECTION 2: CORE ARCHITECTURE — OVERVIEW

One of the most striking differences between Indo-European languages (Greek, Latin, English) and Semitic ones (Hebrew, Arabic, Syriac) is syntax and the copula (“to be”).

In English, we say “God **is** good.” In Greek, “ὁ θεὸς ἀγαθός **ἐστίν**.” We require a verb to link the subject to its predicate. In Syriac, as in Hebrew and Arabic, the “is” functions implicitly. You simply place two nouns, or a noun and an adjective, next to one another.

Alāhā ṭābā = God [is] good.

Cross-Linguistic Comparison: The Definite Article

Another major shift is how Syriac handles “the”.

- **Hebrew** uses a prefix: מֶלֶךְ (ha-melek, “the king”).
- **Arabic** uses a prefix: الملك (al-malik, “the king”).
- **Greek** uses a separate word: ὁ βασιλεὺς (ho basileus, “the king”).
- **Syriac** originally used a **suffix** (the Emphatic State Alaph: ܐ). Over time, this state became the default form. Thus, *malkā* (ܡܠܟܐ) can mean “a king” or “the king” depending on context, but it is structurally the emphatic, determinate form.

SECTION 3: PRONOUNS AND PARTICLES

1. Independent Personal Pronouns

Pronouns stand alone as the subject of a sentence. They distinguish gender in the 2nd and 3rd persons (unlike English “you” or “they”).

2. The Particles **d-** and **l-**

Syriac relies heavily on tiny prepositions that attach directly to the front of the next word.

- **The Relative Particle **d-** (ܕ):** This acts like the English “of”, “which”, “who”, or “that”. It defines relationships and possession.
 - *Malkūtā d-Alāhā* (The kingdom **of** God)
 - *Nūhrā d-ṭābā* (The light **which** is good)
- **The Preposition **l-** (ܠ):** This means “to” or “for”, but it is also used heavily as a Direct Object marker (similar to the Hebrew **et** ֶת, though functioning prepositionally).
 - *l-malkā* (to the king)

- *l-Yūḥannan* (to Yukhannan)

SECTION 4: INDEPENDENT PRONOUNS PARADIGM

Here are the independent personal pronouns in Syriac. Observe the similarities to other Semitic languages.

PERSON	ESTRANGELA	TRANSLITERATION	TRANSLATION	ARABIC COGNATE	HEBREW COGNATE
1 c.sg.	ܐܢܐ	'enā	I	anā (أنا)	'ānī (אני)
2 m.sg.	ܐܢܬܐ	'ant	You (m)	'anta (أنت)	'attāh (אתה)
2 f.sg.	ܐܢܬܝ	'anti	You (f)	'anti (أنتِ)	'att (את)
3 m.sg.	ܐܘܐ	hū	He / It	huwa (هو)	hū ' (הוא)
3 f.sg.	ܐܘܝܐ	hī	She / It	hiya (هي)	hī ' (היא)
1 c.pl.	ܐܡܢܐ	ḥnan	We	naḥnu (نحن)	'ānaḥnū (אנחנו)
2 m.pl.	ܐܢܬܡܐ	'antūn	You (m.pl)	'antum (أنتم)	'attem (אתם)
2 f.pl.	ܐܢܬܡܝ	'antēn	You (f.pl)	'antunna (أنتن)	'atten (אתן)
3 m.pl.	ܐܘܪܐ	hennōn	They (m)	hum (هم)	hēm (הם)
3 f.pl.	ܐܘܪܝܐ	hennēn	They (f)	hunna (هنّ)	hēn (הן)

Note: In 'ant, 'anti, 'antūn, and 'antēn, the 'n' is historically written but often silent in pronunciation (assimilated: "at", "ati").

SECTION 5: THE EMPHATIC NOUN STATE

In the absolute state, the word for king is *malk*. In the emphatic state (the standard dictionary form), an 'Alaph is added.

GENDER	ABSOLUTE STATE	EMPHATIC STATE (DEFAULT)	TRANSLITERATION
Masc.	ܡܠܟܐ	ܡܠܟܐ	malkā (King)
Fem.	ܡܠܟܬܐ	ܡܠܟܬܐ	malkūtā (Kingdom)

Rule of Thumb: If a noun ends in -ā (Alaph), it's overwhelmingly likely to be a masculine emphatic singular or a feminine emphatic.

SECTION 6: THEOLOGICAL VOCABULARY

The following core nouns feature prominently in classical Syriac literature and the Peshitta (the Syriac

Bible).

ESTRANGELA	TRANSLIT	GENDER	MEANING	ETYMOLOGY / NOTES
ܐܠܗܐ	Alāhā	m.	God	Cognate w/ Arabic <i>Allāh</i> , Heb <i>ʿĒlōhīm</i>
ܒܪܢܫܐ	barnāšā	m.	Human, son of man	Compounded from <i>bar</i> (son) + <i>nāšā</i> (man). Standard term for human.
ܡܠܟܐ	malkā	m.	King	Semitic root <i>m-l-k</i>
ܡܠܟܘܬܐ	malkūtā	f.	Kingdom	Abstract noun ending <i>-ūtā</i>
ܡܠܬܐ	meltā	f.	Word, Logos	The Syriac translation of Greek <i>Logos</i> (John 1:1)
ܢܗܪܐ	nūhrā	m.	Light	Root <i>n-h-r</i> . Cf. Arabic <i>nūr</i>
ܐܪܥܐ	ʿar ʿ ā	f.	Earth, land	Cognate with Hebrew <i>ʿereṣ</i> , Arabic <i>ʿarḍ</i>
ܬܒܐ	ṭābā	m.	Good	Adjective behaving as noun. Heb <i>ṭōb</i>
ܒܝܫܐ	bīšā	m.	Evil, bad	Adjective behaving as noun.
ܝܘܗܢܢ	Yūḥannan	m.	John	Proper Name.
ܪܒܐ	rabbā	m.	Great, large	Root <i>r-b-b</i> . Cf. “Rabbi” (my great one).
ܚܝܐ	ḥayyē	m.pl.	Life	Root <i>ḥ-y-y</i> . Plural form (like Heb <i>ḥayyīm</i>)

The Setting

Narrative note: This introductory passage is written entirely in verbless sentences, establishing the setting and main characters using classical equational syntax, pronouns, and the relational d- particle.

Sentence 1

𐤌𐤊𐤍𐤏𐤍 malkā hū. malkā (a-king) hū (he-[is]). → He is a king. / There is a king.

Sentence 2

ጠቅላይ ልብ ወለድ w-malküttā d-malkā rabbā hī. w- (and-) malküttā (the-kingdom) d- (of) malkā (the-king) rabbā (great) hī (she-[is]). → And the kingdom of the king is great. (Note: ‘malküttā’ is feminine, so the pronoun ‘hī’ is used).

Sentence 3

ܐܪܡ ܕܒܝܫܐ ܗܘ. barnāšā bīšā hū. barnāšā (the-man) bīšā (evil) hū (he-[is]). → The man is evil.

Sentence 4

ܝܘܠܬܐܢܐܢ ܗܘܐ ܬܒܐ. Yūhannan hū tābā. Yūhannan (John) hū (he-[is]) tābā (good). → Yukhannan is good.

Sentence 5

ᐱᐤ ᐱᐤᐤ ᐱᐤᐤ ᐱᐤᐤ Alāhā l-Yūḥannan nūhrā hū. Alāhā (God) l- (to/for) Yūḥannan (John) nūhrā (light) hū (he-[is]). → God is light to Yukhannan.

Sentence 6

מֵלְתָּא דְּאַלְהָא בְּ- 'ar 'ā hī. meltā (the-word) d- (of) Alāhā (God) b- (in)
'ar 'ā (the-earth) hī (she-[is]). → The word of God is in the earth.

Sentence 7

ܡܠܟܐ ܒ- ܐܪܥܐ ܝܫܬܐܢܢܐ ܠ-ܡܠܟܐ ܢܘܗܪܐ ܗܘ. malkā b- 'ar 'ā, w-Yūḥannan l-malkā nūhrā hū. malkā (the-king) b- (in) 'ar 'ā (the-earth), w- (and) Yūḥannan (John) l- (to) malkā (the-king) nūhrā (light) hū (he-[is]). → The king is in the earth, and Yukhannan is a light to the king.

SECTION 8: EXERCISES

Exercise 1: Pronoun Identification

Identify the person, gender, and number of the following pronouns, and give the English translation.

1. ܐܢܢ (ḥnan)
2. ܗܝ (hī)
3. ܐܢܬܘܢ (ʾ antūn)
4. ܗܢܢܘܢ (hennōn)
5. ܗܘ (hū)

Exercise 2: Morphology (Nouns)

Identify whether the following words are taking the Emphatic State suffix (-ā).

1. ܢܗܪܐ (nūhrā)
2. ܡܠܟܐ (malk)
3. ܬܒܐ (ṭābā)

Exercise 3: Translation Drill (Syriac → English)

Translate the following basic verbless clauses into English.

1. Alāhā hū ṭābā.
2. Nūhrā b-malkūtā hū.
3. Yūḥannan barnāšā hū.
4. Meltā d-malkā bīšā hī.
5. ʾ Enā Yūḥannan.

Exercise 4: Production Drill (English → Syriac)

Render the following English sentences into Syriac transliteration using verbless clauses. (Remember to include the correct 3rd person pronoun at the end to act as “is”).

1. God is a great light.
2. The earth is the kingdom of God. (Earth is feminine *hī*).
3. The king is an evil man.

4. I am the king. (No “is” pronoun needed, just “I king”).

Exercise 5: Reading Comprehension

Re-read the story in Section 7 and answer the following:

1. What adjective is used to describe the king’s kingdom?
 2. To whom is Yukhannan a “light”?
 3. Where is the word of God?
-

SECTION 9: ANSWER KEY

Section 1 Warm-Up

1. Three consonants (the triliteral root).
2. Right to left.
3. A sentence lacking a verb (like “to be”), where subject and predicate are placed adjacently (e.g., “The man [is] good”).
4. Usually a glottal stop or silent carrier for a vowel.
5. m-l-k.

Exercise 1: Pronoun Identification

1. 1 c.pl. (We)
2. 3 f.sg. (She)
3. 2 m.pl. (You all)
4. 3 m.pl. (They, m)
5. 3 m.sg. (He)

Exercise 2: Morphology

1. Yes (Ends in Alaph/ ā).
2. No (Absolute state).
3. Yes (Ends in Alaph/ ā).

Exercise 3: Translation

1. God is good.
2. The light is in the kingdom.
3. Yuxhannan is a man.
4. The word of the king is evil. (Because *meltā* is feminine, *hī* is used).
5. I am Yuxhannan.

Exercise 4: Production

1. Alāhā nūhrā rabbā hū.
2. 'ar 'ā malkūttā d-Alāhā hī.
3. Malkā barnāšā bīšā hū.
4. 'Enā malkā.

Exercise 5: Comprehension

1. Great (*rabbā*).
2. To the king (*l-malkā*).
3. In the earth (*b- 'ar 'ā*).

SECTION 10: GRAMMATICAL SUMMARY

THE VERBLESS CLAUSE — FORMATION RULES

COMPONENT 1	COMPONENT 2	COPULA (PRONOUN)	TRANSLATION
Subject Noun	Predicate Noun/Adj	Pronoun matching Subject	
Alāhā (God)	ṭābā (good)	hū (he)	God is good.
Meltā (Word)	rabbā (great)	hī (she)	The word is great.

PRONOUN REFERENCE TABLE

PERSON	SINGULAR	PLURAL
1st Common	' enā (I)	ḥnan (We)
2nd Masc	' ant (You)	' antūn (You all)
2nd Fem	' anti (You)	' antēn (You all)
3rd Masc	hū (He)	hennōn (They)
3rd Fem	hī (She)	hennēn (They)

SECTION 11: ADDITIONAL VOCABULARY

The following high-frequency words round out this lesson's vocabulary to 30 terms.

SYRIAC (ESTRANGELA)	TRANSLITERATION	PART OF SPEECH	MEANING	NOTES
ܩܪܝܬܐ	qṛītā	f. noun	village	emphatic state
ܠܫܢܐ	leššānā	m. noun	tongue, language	
ܟܕܝܐ	garmā	m. noun	bone	
ܟܦܐ	kēpā	f. noun	stone, rock	
ܡܝܐ	māyā	m. noun (pl.)	water	plural in form
ܢܘܢܐ	nūnā	m. noun	fish	
ܡܕܝܬܐ	mdittā	f. noun	city	
ܫܡܫܐ	šemšā	m. noun	sun	
ܬܪܝܐ	tar'ā	m. noun	door, gate	
ܡܫܗܐ	mešhā	m. noun	oil	
ܫܠܐ	ḥaylā	m. noun	power, army	
ܐܕܢܐ	'ednā	f. noun	ear	
ܩܝܣܐ	qaysā	m. noun	wood, tree	
ܢܗܪܐ	nahrā	m. noun	river	
ܫܒܪܐ	sabrā	m. noun	hope	
ܕܗܠܬܐ	dehltā	f. noun	fear, religion	abstract noun
ܫܗܪܐ	sahrā	m. noun	moon	
ܪܓܠܐ	reglā	f. noun	foot	
ܫܠܡܐ	šlāmā	m. noun	peace	common greeting
ܐܬܪܐ	'atrā	m. noun	place, country	
ܫܗܕܐ	sāhdā	m. noun	witness, martyr	
ܒܫܪܐ	besrā	m. noun	flesh	
ܬܝܒܘܬܐ	ṭaybūtā	f. noun	grace	

SYRIAC (ESTRANGELA)	TRANSLITERATION	PART OF SPEECH	MEANING	NOTES
ܬܐܪܐ	tawrā	m. noun	bull, ox	
ܩܝܡܐ	qyāmā	m. noun	covenant	
ܪܘܚܐ	ʾūrḥā	f. noun	way, road	
ܚܝܠܐ	hayklā	m. noun	temple, palace	
ܥܝܢܐ	ʿaynā	f. noun	eye	
ܦܡܐ	pūmā	m. noun	mouth	
ܕܝܢܐ	dīnā	m. noun	judgment	